

Cloud

According to a survey carried out by RightScale on adoption of private cloud by corporations, 64 per cent of respondents plan to include a private cloud option as part of their portfolio – open source private cloud solutions are taking the lead. A lot of industry honchos are speculating that open source cloud offerings may become the de facto dominant platforms for private clouds. InfoWorld's Oliver Rist has gone ahead and said that OpenStack, one of the many open source private cloud options, has become the "new Linux".

The point here is that more or less most of the corporations around the world are moving their entire infrastructures to the cloud to save on operation costs and thus are on the lookout for engineers and cloud specialists who will help them virtualise their products and infrastructure. The cloud is also the major talking point among the CTOs and CIOs around the world. They are either already in the process of switching over or are in the planning stages for doing so. Nearly 80 per cent of the workload in the cloud are on open source technologies. This provides clear indicators for exciting career paths in this domain.

Enterprise

According to the 2012 Future of Open Source Survey which was carried out on 740 companies – OSS deployment is reaching a tipping point: 32 per cent of the survey respondents reported that OSS deployment has reached 75 per cent, and a further 30 per cent indicate that OSS will make up between 51 to 75 per cent of all software deployment.

The main poster boy of enterprise OSS is Linux. The Linux Foundation in its recent job report said that of the 2,300 survey respondents, eight in ten said that hiring Linux talent is a priority in 2012. 63 per cent of the employers seek more Linux talent relative to the other skill areas. "Linux professionals garner more full-time positions and better salaries, bonuses and perks. While the pay increase for IT professionals averaged just two per cent in 2011, Linux professionals have seen a five per cent increase in salaries every year, and a 15 per cent jump in bonus payouts. They also enjoy

flexible work schedules (37 per cent) additional training and certification programs (30 per cent) and salary increases above the company norm (28 per cent)." said Andy Karandikar of Red Hat.

Where to start?

So how do you actually start developing, contributing or working on an open source project and get noticed and hired, well the best thing to do is to dive right in. All you need is rudimentary to intermediate programming knowledge in the programming language of your

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– John Resig, creator of the jQuery JavaScript library

choice. It can be anything from C, C++, Java, JavaScript, Python, Ruby, Node.js, Drupal, Linux, OpenStack, RoR, Scala or for that matter HTML5 and CSS3 – anything that you're comfortable with. Next, search for projects that you like that are built on your language of choice – often, it turns out to be something you're already using on a daily basis. Start with reporting problems and bugs, and it's even better if you can fix the said bugs. This will allow you to post the results back to the community, or send a patch to the maintainer. Next you start looking for ways to add new features,

or enhance existing ones, and discuss it with the community and the developers. If you are capable, the next step is to develop and integrate said features or enhancements into the project yourself. The community is helpful, and will give you feedback whenever required, and even act as beta testers.

"When it comes to hiring, I'll take a Github commit log over a CV any day.", says John Resig, the brains behind jQuery, a popular JavaScript framework. This goes to show the importance of being a part of the community. Since most new enterprises have a lot of OSS, they make sure that their employees are involved in the community – if you're already involved, that's one less step of training for them. In fact, very often, people from the community are the first ones contacted for job openings.

Another interesting point here that anyone can join an open source project even a developer who has only worked on closed-source projects thus far. As Andy Karandikar points out, "the beauty of the open source model is that it is open. One can switch in and out of open source software or leverage open source software at any time. One does not have to buy expensive resources to get access to the software. However, one has to adopt the collaborative model of open source, and be mentally prepared that the source will be up for review by peers."

In summation

As you can tell from this article, there's no real magic mantra to becoming a success in OSS. Like anything else, it will take hard work and passion for you to get to where you'd like to be in the IT world. The aim of this article is to give you a kick in the right direction towards finding your own way because, honestly, with the sheer amount of languages out there, the myriad of ways in which OSS is being used, there's no dearth of opportunities. There are a lot of roads for you to take. All you have to do is do what you do best, code like a madman, never be afraid to try new things, and keep your eyes peeled for a job or project that you'd like to be a part of. The world is always going to need software to improve, be searching for new software, and for new people to fill in the gaps that will be created by the adoption of new software. Best of luck! 



The opportunities in OSS are limitless